
The Morning: The pope and the president

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The New York Times The Morning

April 14, 2026



By **Sam Sifton**

Good morning. The two most powerful Americans in the world — the pope and the president — are clashing.



In Algiers. Guglielmo Mangiapane/Reuters

President vs. pope

Pope Leo's [visit to Algeria today](#) was meant to be stirring. The first member of the Order of Augustine to ascend to the papacy is visiting the place where Augustine was bishop starting in A.D. 395.

Instead, President Trump is hammering him.

Leo doesn't like to see war in the Middle East. Trump doesn't like other leaders criticizing him, even implicitly. After he called the pope "weak on crime" and posted an A.I. image of himself as a Jesus-like figure, he said, "I'm just responding to Pope Leo."

The pontiff seemed unfazed. ("Too many innocent people are being killed," he said on his way to a 10-day Africa tour. "Someone has to stand up and say there's a better way.") But Catholic clerics in America [called on Trump to apologize](#). He declined.

It's an odd conflict. The people in these two roles have generally treated each other with deference, or pretended to. What gives?

A curious tableau



Donald J. Trump  
@realDonaldTrump



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Trump's A.I. answer to Pope Leo. via Truth Social

This image Trump posted, then deleted, was especially strange, and not only because the patient in it bears a resemblance to Jon Stewart, [as the late night hosts pointed out](#).

I asked Jason Farago, our art critic, about it:

The image — do not call it a painting — is like other works of propaganda during this second term: the ideology of Leni Riefenstahl expressed in the style of Lisa Frank. The incumbent appears as Christ the Healer. Supplicants, or their disembodied heads, ring the messiah-president like the saints and donors in an early Renaissance altarpiece; note the grizzled veteran at left, whose cap has nonsense A.I. lettering more Cyrillic than Roman.

When he took down the image, Trump said he hadn't meant to compare himself to Jesus. "I thought it was me as a doctor," he said.

Popes and politics

Lots of popes have waded into the political muck, as my colleague Elisabetta Povoledo [reports from Rome](#).

Pope Francis, who died last year, hated poverty and climate change. He was also more compassionate about migration and homosexuality than his predecessors.

In 1979, John Paul II, the first Polish pope, told students in Krakow: Don't be afraid to reject totalitarian oppression. It took 10 more years for communism there to fall.

Pius XII is remembered for what he *didn't* say: As the pope during World War II, he avoided explicitly condemning the Nazis.

A question of stability

Where is all this rancor from the president coming from? Peter Baker, who has covered six presidencies, [wrote about that yesterday](#):

Trump's erratic behavior and extreme comments in recent days and weeks have turbocharged the crazy-like-a-fox-or-just-plain-crazy debate that has followed him on the national political stage for a decade.

It's a debate you can see in the polls. A Reuters/Ipsos poll in February found that 61 percent of Americans think Trump has become more erratic with age. Just 45 percent say he is "mentally sharp and able to deal with challenges." That's down from 54 percent in 2023.

Trump’s language fuels the fire. “He uses more profanity, speaks longer and regularly makes comments rooted in fantasy rather than fact,” Peter writes:

He wanders off into odd tangents — an eight-minute ramble at a Christmas reception about poisonous snakes in Peru, a long digression during a cabinet meeting about Sharpie pens, an interruption of an Iran war update to praise the White House drapes. He has confused Greenland with Iceland and more than once boasted of ending a fictional war between Cambodia and Azerbaijan, two countries separated by nearly 4,000 miles. (He evidently means Armenia and Azerbaijan).

Still, part of Trump’s base loves it. A Princeton historian put this question to Peter: “What can be more anti-establishment than someone who is willing to be out of control?”



THE LATEST NEWS

War in Iran



A billboard in Iran showing the Strait of Hormuz, saying "Forever in Iran's hands." Arash Khamooshi for The New York Times

The U.S. and Iran are [trading proposals](#) on nuclear restrictions. Iran said it could suspend its uranium enrichment for up to five years, but the Trump administration insisted on 20 years, officials from both countries said.

A deal on those lines [would buy time](#), but it wouldn't solve deeper problems, my colleagues David Sanger and Tyler Pager write.

Officials also said they were discussing a second round of face-to-face talks.

Since the U.S. has announced a blockade of Iranian ports on the Strait of Hormuz, [several ships coming from Iran](#) have still been able to cross the strait.

There's little precedent for such a blockade, and the military has offered few details about its plan. John Ismay, a former naval officer, [explains how it might work](#).

Many Americans have [expressed bewilderment](#) about a conflict that came with little warning.

Congress

Eric Swalwell, a Democratic congressman from the San Francisco Bay Area, [said he'll resign](#) after allegations that he sexually assaulted a former staff member and engaged in misconduct with other women. He suspended his campaign to be California governor yesterday.

Tony Gonzales, a Republican congressman from Texas accused of having a coercive sexual relationship with a staff member who later killed herself, [said he would resign as well](#).

More on Politics

In California, Democrats are [struggling to identify the right candidate for governor](#). Here are [the candidates still running](#).

Prosecutors are investigating ICE agents who in January [arrested a Minnesota man in his underwear](#). (Images of the arrest went viral on social media.)

A federal judge dismissed Trump's [\\$10 billion defamation lawsuit against The Wall Street Journal](#) over its report of his lewd birthday greeting to Jeffrey Epstein. Trump has said the message was not his.

Around the World



A pier on the Irrawaddy River, looking out toward Yangon, Myanmar. Daniel Berehulak/The New York Times

Myanmar: Five years into a civil war, fear consumes everyday life. [A reporter and a photographer for The Times](#) traveled the country and found a population terrified of one another, and of the next attack.

Hungary: Viktor Orban's [election defeat](#) ends his run as Europe's pre-eminent populist leader. [Many Hungarians rejoiced](#), but U.S. members of the MAGA movement [were worried](#).

Canada: Prime Minister Mark Carney, who has governed for a year without a Commons majority, [now has one](#) after three special parliamentary elections.

China: Beijing has enacted sweeping regulations to [investigate and punish foreign companies](#) that stop using Chinese suppliers.

OPINIONS

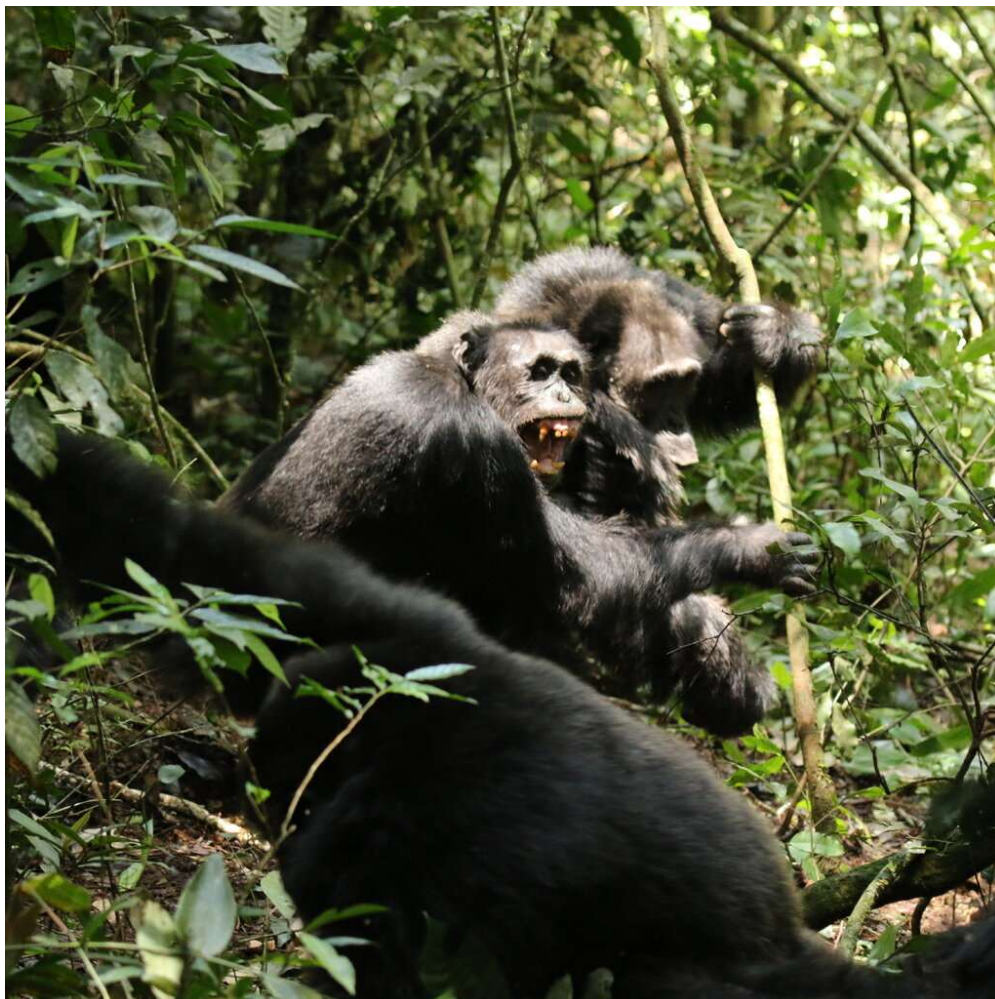
Looking to pay less than \$20,000 for a car? Good luck. **Clifford Winston** explains [how cars got so expensive](#).

The U.S. has helped fix crises around the world. [Sudan needs help now](#), **Ann Curry** writes.

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MORNING READS



Going ape: These chimps began a bloody “civil war” that has continued for years. [No one knows why.](#)

Extra syrup: Chains like Dunkin’ and Starbucks already sell more cold drinks than hot ones. Now McDonald’s is introducing [fruit-flavored refresher drinks.](#)

Two-button rule: Men are generally advised to leave open the bottom button of their suits. [Why?](#)

Your pick: The most-clicked story in The Morning yesterday was [about Lauren Sánchez Bezos.](#)

Insect carwash: A unique “choreography” between two ant species suggests a partnership in which one [cleans the other.](#)



TODAY’S NUMBER

90

— *That is the number of seconds it takes the massive, revolving, two-story set of “Innocence” at the Metropolitan Opera in New York to transform, as if in a series of magic tricks, from a fancy restaurant into a school cafeteria and classroom. The size of the team that makes that possible is astonishing. [Look at the pictures.](#)*

SPORTS

W.N.B.A.: The Dallas Wings selected UConn guard Azzi Fudd with [the No. 1 pick](#) in the draft, reuniting her with former Huskies teammate Paige Bueckers, the top pick in 2025.

College basketball: ESPN broadcaster Dick Vitale, 86, who has battled multiple forms of cancer, announced that he [has been diagnosed](#) with melanoma.

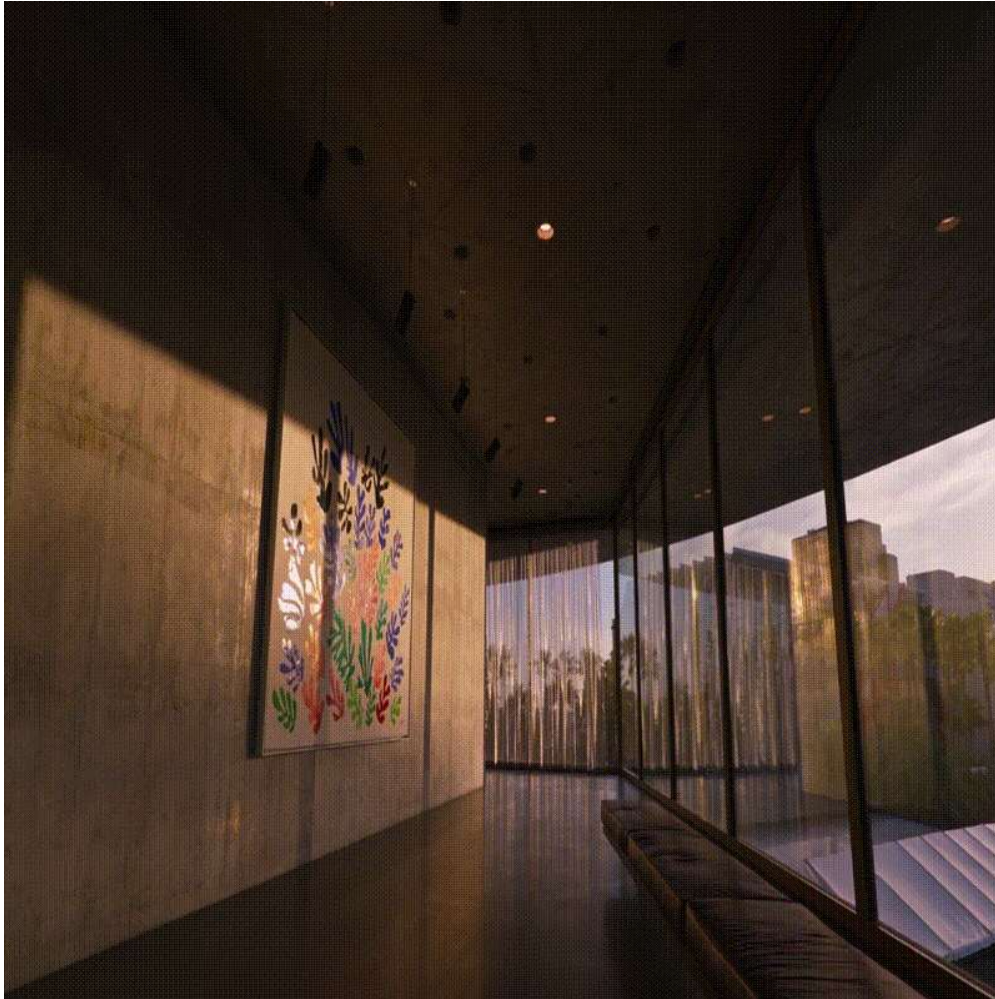
RECIPE OF THE DAY



Linda Xiao for The New York Times

Eric Kim's from Atlanta, where lemon-pepper chicken wings emerged, and his [recipe for them](#) is legitimate. I cook them a little differently, though. I make a mixture of lemon pepper, cornstarch and kosher salt, then swirl some neutral oil into it to make a kind of slurry. I toss my wings in that before roasting them on a rack in a sheet pan, which gives the chicken a shatteringly crisp crust. Then I toss them in butter, hot sauce and more lemon pepper, as if they were Buffalo wings. In Atlanta, they call that *lemon pepper wet*. With enough celery and carrot and ranch dressing, it makes for a lovely, messy weeknight dinner.

THE AMOEBA



Jake Michaels for The New York Times

Michael Kimmelman, our architecture critic, took measure of the new \$724 million home for the Los Angeles County Museum of Art, called the David Geffen Galleries for the donor who gave \$150 million to the cause. Kimmelman calls the building “spectacular”:

By turns uplifting, lyrical and pugnacious, the new Geffen Galleries bid to alter the cultural and civic weather of Los Angeles and reassert the city’s role as an American petri dish for experimental design and derring-do.

The museum opens to the public on May 4. “I expect it will be wildly popular,” Michael said. [Read his whole review.](#)

More on culture

Oasis, Phil Collins and Sade will [enter the Rock & Roll Hall of Fame](#) this year, alongside Billy Idol, Iron Maiden and Wu-Tang Clan. Who failed to make the cut? Among others: Jeff Buckley, Mariah Carey and Melissa Etheridge.

“Comebacks require landing places,” writes Jon Caramanica, our pop music critic, about the [return of the rapper once known as Kanye West](#).

“For almost his whole career, Ye has been tempting fate with a combination of alienating people and wooing them right back. But in this moment, his ability to do both at once is more brittle than ever.”

Influencers tried begging and manifesting to [get someone to pay their way](#) to see Justin Bieber perform at Coachella.

THE MORNING RECOMMENDS



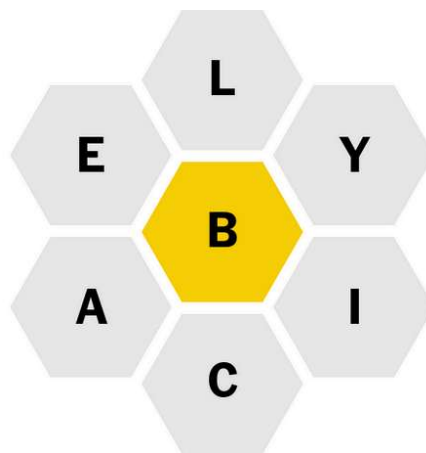
David Cross Ye Fan for The New York Times

Spend a day with the comedian David Cross. [People in show business who aren't global superstars lead interesting lives.](#)

Step up [your body-weight workout](#) — literally.

Watch Stephen Colbert riff on The Morning's [conversion of the moon mission's mileage into Dachshunds.](#)

GAMES



Here is [today's Spelling Bee](#). Yesterday's pangrams were *outgrowth* and *wrought*.

And here are [today's Mini Crossword](#), [Wordle](#), [Connections](#), [Crossplay](#) and [Strands](#).

Thanks for spending part of your morning with The Times and me. If you want to see more of my colleagues' great reporting in your Google search results, take a minute to add The Times as a preferred source. It's easy: [Just click this link](#). See you tomorrow.
— Sam

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